Coalition To Restore Coastal Louisiana: Healing The Gulf

www.crcl.org

This interview was conducted with James Karst, Communications Director, Coalition to Restore Coastal Louisiana.

Ever venture out beyond the French Quarter, the streetcars, and the festivals in New Orleans to see a different part of Louisiana? If you have not, you should.

The Louisiana coast has just as much magic and treasure that locals and tourists alike can enjoy. Hurricane Katrina's devastation in the city is well documented, but the damage caused by the storm's massive surge on the state's coastal areas was also catastrophic, only adding to existing challenges. For close to a century, Louisiana's coastal wetlands have been disappearing at a very rapid pace and are being taken over by water, eventually becoming part of the Gulf of Mexico. The reality is that the closer the Gulf is to communities in South Louisiana, the higher the risk of tropical storms and hurricanes. The sea level is rising, and the ground is sinking, which is a devastating one-two punch.

For nearly 40 years, the Coalition to Restore Coastal Louisiana has been fighting to preserve Louisiana's wetlands as much as possible. Over the years, thousands of volunteers have planted over one million trees and marsh grasses, and recycled over 17 million pounds of oyster shells. The organization's mission is to unite people in action to achieve a thriving, sustainable Louisiana coast for all.

Q: Twenty years after Katrina, what does your organization's existence say about New Orleans' resilience and the community's ability to rebuild on its own terms?

James Karst: I think one of the most important things people may not always recognize is that our state really took great strides toward addressing coastal land loss and helping to connect it to public consciousness with hurricanes. People now better understand that there is a relationship between wetland loss and the severity of storms that we get in this area. As the saying goes, you have to recognize there is a problem before you can address it. And something that my organization doubled down on was the creation of a state agency that would lead coordinated restoration of Louisiana's coast. Before that effort, it was just multiple local groups doing this type of work on their own, and no real strategy behind it. Now, that has changed. After [Hurricane] Katrina, our state created the Coastal Protection and Restoration Authority, which is the most effective and, in my mind, the most efficient state agency that is doing really good work, now with a unified master plan.

On a different level, we work with thousands of volunteers every year. And that has been really gratifying to see because I think that people often think of natural disasters as problems that are too big for them. Through our volunteer events, we are giving people an outlet to do this type of work themselves and to show the strength in collaboration by like-minded people. And we are reaching people not just from Louisiana, but from all over the nation. It is an extraordinary, positive thing [to witness] and is empowering. These volunteers are accomplishing something great. For example, the volunteers help us build oyster reefs. Oyster reefs interrupt wave action that is causing erosion, so the waves begin to crash against them instead of the very soft soil. This barrier of shells helps dramatically stop the speedy rate of erosion. It almost feels like putting a Band-Aid on the earth. When people volunteer with us, it is not just about sticking plants into the dirt or dropping oyster shells into the water. They are also learning about what we can do to preserve it and become advocates for restoration projects.

Q: How has the grant money from BCM helped your organization and its goals?

Karst: We do volunteer events throughout the year, so this money has helped to support our work in St. Bernard and the lower Ninth Ward, where we take volunteers to our restoration headquarters, which is located in Violet, La. Throughout the year, we will take an oyster shell that is recycled by New Orleans restaurants and place it into these marine-grade mesh bags, and place it into the water to make an oyster reef. The money has also helped us offset the cost of the transportation of the shell, which happens several times weekly, from dozens of restaurant partners. We also used this money to feed our volunteers after completing projects. So, this type of funding has helped to support these kinds of efforts, making it possible for us to accommodate our wonderful volunteers. Also, people collect cypress seeds from their trees and yards. We take those seeds, grow baby trees from those seeds, and plant those trees out in the marsh. We've also used the grant to pay for seed containers, soil, and tools.

Q: What do you think volunteers or others who have engaged with the Coalition to Restore Coastal Louisiana would say about their experiences?

Karst: I would think most of them would say our events are important, fun, and impactful. And I am talking about some strenuous work. Our days involve hour-long boat rides and building oyster reefs by hand, and by the end of the day, you can tell our volunteers see the positive impact from their work. Our staff feels the same way. It's always a fun adventure. And we get to look back six months, two years, and even five years later and see the progress made. Seeing baby oysters, crabs, and birds as that area becomes a thriving ecosystem again. It's a really powerful thing.

Q: After returning post-Hurricane Katrina, how has the Coalition to Restore Coastal Louisiana continued to partner with fishermen and restaurants in the area?

Karst: In Louisiana, we are so tied to our culture. It is just a unique place in America, and that is something that is very special and tied to the fisheries. It has made New Orleans the tourist destination that it is today-our famous restaurants and dishes have all been driven by our seafood industry. But there is sometimes this perception that seafood and the restoration of Louisiana's coastal lands are at odds. Our organization has shown that it doesn't have to be that way. People who are fishing, shrimping, or harvesting oysters off our coast obviously depend on healthy wetlands as well. The fishermen have been very willing to jump in and contribute to our work as well. We also have restaurant partners who participate in our oyster shell recycling programs. We also did an event last year with the Super Bowl, and built an oyster reef in Leeville, La. We partnered with oystermen and oysterwomen who shucked fresh oysters for the volunteers. So, it's really been about making this very direct connection to the seafood/restaurant industry and the efforts to save Louisiana's wetlands.

Support CRCL

Your support makes this work possible. A gift of any size helps CRCL continue serving the community and building a stronger, more resilient city for everyone.

Donate to CRCL